Lichtenberg were turned to rubble,' he observed. 'That afternoon the sun was obscured, the day turned into night, lit only by the many fires. All hell broke loose. Time and again incendiary bombs fell on the roofs of the women's prison, and we tossed them off.'

In this remarkable atmosphere – horrific though it was – Honecker's roving eye spotted Charlotte Schanuel, a former civil servant in the Prussian civil service who had been conscripted as a prison warder. Although nine years his senior, the attraction was mutual, and sex was fast and rewarding, presumably snatched in dark cells and washrooms. Charlotte, though, was no passing fancy. Their illicit encounters would out-see the end of the conflict and beyond.

As the war's problems became more intractable, senior military leaders carried out a failed assassination attempt on Hitler in July 1944. Revenge was swift. Within days, thousands were arrested and imprisoned in the most appalling conditions – Brandenburg-Görden was suddenly crammed with 4,000 inmates and, in an orgy of bloodshed, at least 2,000 resistance fighters were murdered either by guillotine or hanging. 'I could have gone, like anyone else into a concentration camp or a probation battalion,' Honecker reflected.9 'That could have been my lot. Not one of the political prisoners at Brandenburg knew what tomorrow would bring him. But we didn't give this a great deal of thought. We fulfilled the tasks of the day.'10

Amid the carnage, Erich received the shattering news that Hitler had also taken the opportunity to order the execution of KPD leader Ernst Thälmann, who had been languishing at Buchenwald concentration camp under the most harrowing and humiliating conditions. Predictably, the Nazis blamed his death on an air-raid, as the Völkischer Beobachter reported:

Killed by Terror Bombs!

During a terrorist attack on the area around Weimar on 28 August 1944, the concentration camp was also hit by numerous